such as the Covid-19 pandemic, its whimsical proclivity to invent crises such as demonetization, its complete disregard for the looming challenge of unemployment and its brazen drive to promote a few cronies while squandering national assets and plundering natural resources. We affirm that at this historic juncture, it cannot be business as usual. Anyone who cares for India, its diversities, its hard-won freedom, its Constitution and for the hope of a dignified future of our coming generations must stand together united and resolve to reclaim the republic.'

It was also decided that the Jodo Yatra would have the national flag as its single symbol and that it wouldn't display any sectarian symbols or party banners. It was also clearly stated that it wouldn't promote any specific party or political formation. And finally the Yatra would devote itself to listening to people, understanding their dreams for the future, gathering and celebrating their memories of Indian independence and assuring each other that people, indeed, could raise their voices when they were fearlessly determined to do so. The Yatra was to dispel fear and make Indians believe that India belonged to them, irrespective of who they were and from where they came in the long past of the country.

Although it was not a stated objective at the time, the Jodo andolan serves as a tribute to those who contributed to making Indians a tolerant people, who dreamt of the idea of freedom and gave their everything for its realization, who sacrificed their lives so that Indians could live as equal and free citizens. In that sense, the Bharat Jodo Yatra was a 'freedom' movement, one that had to be launched in a country once freed from the colonial masters. If the Chhodo Bharat movement could do that, the Jodo Bharat movement can do so now in our present context. Seeing it in any lesser perspective is to misjudge its purpose and its potential.

Soon after the Yatra Started: Shaping a New Idiom

At a time when the Indian rupee had further taken a tumble, the unseasonal rains had wreaked havoc on standing crops, the Bilkis Bano case convicts